EL SALVADOR (30 October)

Normal to above-normal precipitation has been reported in September, as well as storm rains and winds across the coastal and western areas caused by hurricane "Isidore" at the end of the month. Satisfactory growing conditions are reported for the 2002/03 second season maize, sorghum and bean crops. Maize output for the year is officially forecast at some 610 000 tonnes which compares to the past 5-year average of 573 000 tonnes. Sorghum production is expected to increase from 140 000 tonnes in 2001/02 to 147 000 tonnes, but would still be below the 5-year average of 168 000 tonnes. An above-average production of beans of 84 000 tonnes is anticipated. Despite the favourable anticipated outputs for the country as a whole, food assistance from the international community is still being distributed in some rural communities particularly in the north-east, where the first season cereal and bean crops from last year and this year were damaged by drought. Food assistance is also being provided in the coffee producing areas in the west, where thousands of workers have been unemployed for a long time due to the international coffee crisis due to falling prices. Severe cases of malnutrition, particularly among children, are reported in the western departments of Sonsonate and Ahuachapán. The possibility of food assistance in other coffee producing areas is also being studied.

